

Ambiguity Court Classroom Run Kit

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • Knowledge and Language • 25-35 min

Category	Knowledge and Language	Time	25-35 min
Difficulty	Easy	ID	ambiguity-court

Big idea: Ambiguity is not just confusion; it reveals how context and assumptions complete meaning.

One-Minute Teacher Brief

Students put ambiguous statements on trial and decide which interpretations are reasonable, strained, or unsupported.

Student Prompt

Inspect Ambiguity Court Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

Ambiguity Court Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: Sentence: 'I saw her duck.' Context A: a birdwatching trip. Context B: a football flying across the room. Annotate the wording. Circle the words that change tone, emotion, implication, or trust.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
Ambiguity Court Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: Sentence: 'The teacher said the student was brilliant with a smile.'. Annotate the wording. Circle the words that change tone, emotion, implication, or trust.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
Ambiguity Court Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: Sentence: 'The teacher said the student was brilliant with a smile.'. Annotate the wording. Circle the words that change tone, emotion, implication, or trust.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — Ambiguity is not just confusion; it reveals how context and assumptions complete meaning.

Actual Lesson Questions

#	Question for students	Teacher key / cue
1	After inspecting Ambiguity Court Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: look for a clear claim, not just a description.
2	Which exact detail from Ambiguity Court Stimulus A did you use as evidence?	Teacher cue: students should name visible words, data, source features, method features, or contextual clues.
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?	Teacher cue: this is where assumptions, framing, models, or perspective usually appear.
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?	Teacher cue: confidence is data for the debrief, not a grade.
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: push for method, source, context, comparison, or definitions.
6	How much meaning is in words and how much is in context?	Teacher cue: students should move from the classroom example to a general TOK issue.

Student Task

Use the stimulus cards to complete the observation/inference/evidence/confidence grid, then answer one TOK knowledge question connected to Knowledge and Language.

Teacher Key / Reveal

The key move is not the “right answer”; it is the moment students see how ambiguity is not just confusion; it reveals how context and assumptions complete meaning.

- Strong response: separates observation from inference.
- Strong response: names a method, source, model, language choice, context, or perspective.
- Strong response: revises confidence when new evidence or a new criterion appears.
- Weak response: gives only opinion or says “it depends” without criteria.

Student Instructions

- Work silently for the first response so you can notice your own starting point.
- Record one knowledge claim, the evidence behind it, and your confidence level.
- After the reveal or comparison, update your claim in a different colour or column.
- Use the debrief to answer: How much meaning is in words and how much is in context?

Setup Checklist

- Choose sentences that are genuinely ambiguous but not socially risky.
- Add context gradually so students can see interpretation change in stages.

Example Stimuli or Materials

- Sentence: 'I saw her duck.' Context A: a birdwatching trip. Context B: a football flying across the room.
- Sentence: 'The teacher said the student was brilliant with a smile.'

Resources To Use

- Resource pack: <resources/ambiguity-court/index.html>
- Card deck CSV: <resources/ambiguity-court/cards.csv>
- Visual prompt: <resources/ambiguity-court/visual-prompt.svg>
- Ambiguity verdict sheet: interpretation, supporting evidence, context needed, verdict.
- Context cards that add speaker, setting, tone, and purpose.

Run Sequence

1. Give groups an ambiguous sentence with no context.
2. Students list as many possible meanings as they can.
3. Add context cards one at a time and ask which meanings become stronger or weaker.
4. Groups defend one interpretation and challenge another.
5. Debrief how context, intention, and audience shape linguistic knowledge.

Debrief Moves

- Knowledge question: How much meaning is in the words and how much is supplied by context?
- When is an interpretation justified rather than merely possible?

- Can ambiguity be useful for knowledge?

Teacher Quick Script

- Possible does not mean equally justified.
- What evidence moved an interpretation from possible to reasonable?

Exit Ticket

- One thing I first treated as evidence was...
- My confidence changed because...
- A better knowledge question I can now ask is...